PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · TIPS

When practice isn't working

You practise every day and it is not getting better. Usually the practice, not the player, needs fixing: too fast, too long, or always from the top.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
You stumble in the same place every time	**the fingering:** write one in and keep it	p. 159
It is fine slowly, wrong at speed	**the ladder:** three correct, then one notch up	p. 161
You play it from the top every time	**small chunks**, hardest first	p. 161
New pieces take forever to learn	**the scan:** key, time, rhythm, patterns	p. 163
You cannot hear your own mistakes	**listening:** record yourself, sing it	p. 165
It falls apart in front of people	**a routine** and practising starts	p. 167

Four ways to unstick practice

1. **Halve the speed**
   Whatever speed you use, try half. Correct and slow beats fast and wrong.

2. **Shorten the chunk**
   If two bars fail, try one. If one fails, try one beat.

3. **Take a break**
   Ten short sessions beat one long one. Your brain keeps learning between them.

4. **Ask a question**
   Write down what goes wrong, and take it to your teacher.

EXAMPLE

Ten minutes left: what do you play?

One bar you keep missing, and a whole piece you know ?

1. **Which needs the time more?**
2. **How many minutes** on the hard bar?
3. **And** the last minutes?

About **seven minutes** on the hard bar, slowly, then play the whole piece once at the end, for joy.

THINK OF IT Practice does not make perfect: perfect practice does. Slow and correct is the fastest way.